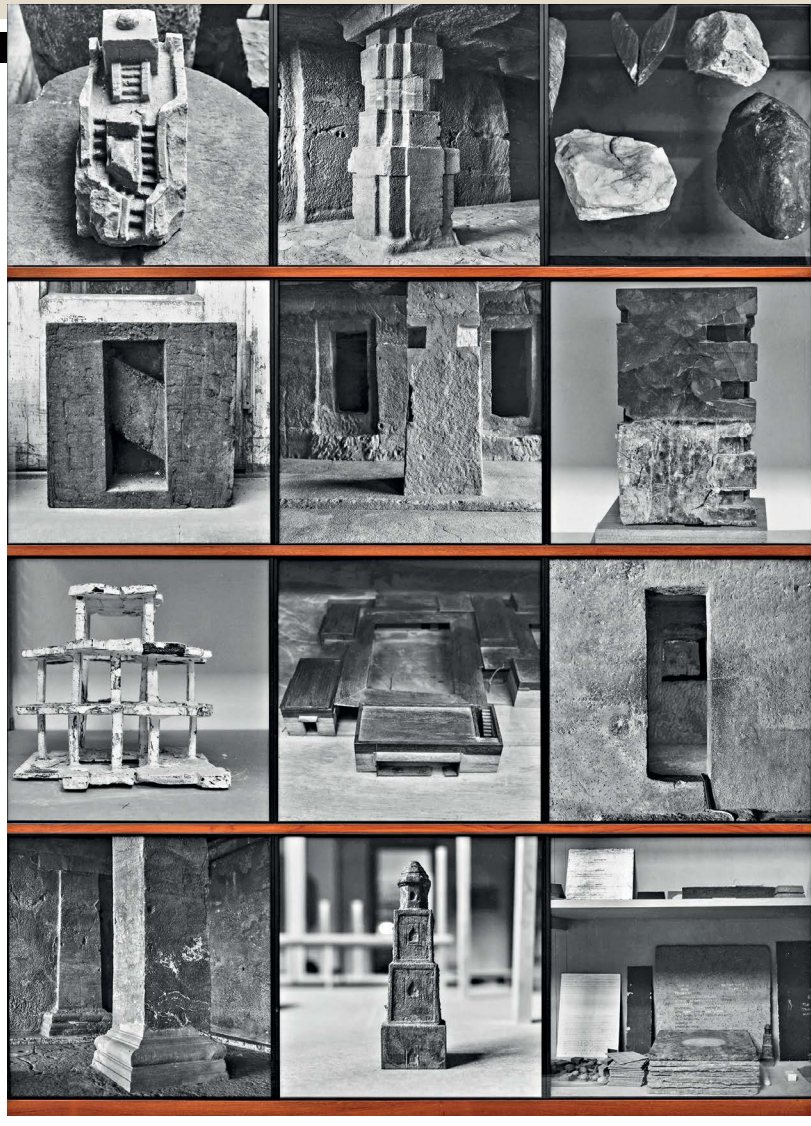


"Photography is a form of deception; it is what the photographer includes and excludes in the frame and what their point of view is," says Dayanita Singh by way of explanation of her exhibition's title. *Photo Lies* is currently on view at the Jehangir Nicholson Art Foundation (JNAF) at Mumbai's Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj Vastu Sangrahalaya (CSMVS). It features extracts from *Dancing with My Camera*, Singh's retrospective that was on tour in Europe in 2022–2024, alongside new pieces created specifically for this exhibition, all of which are being presented for the first time in India.

The deception in photography is evident throughout the exhibition, particularly in the 'montages', where Singh cuts up her own images and recombines them to make analogue compositions. Her architectural montages are particularly striking, seamlessly combining Kanyakumari's 17th-century Padmanabhapuram Palace with the Geoffrey Bawa-designed Heritance Kandalama Hotel in Sri Lanka. Or an ancient Kyoto temple juxtaposed with the modernist library designed by Rahul Mehrotra at CEPT, Ahmedabad. "The space that I create in the montage is fictional; it only exists in that photograph and yet it is real because now there is an image of it," says Singh. The key idea is to collapse time and geography, ostensibly to counter the frequently asked question that has always annoyed Singh—where and when was this photo taken? Elsewhere in the exhibition, Singh paints over her photographs to create ghosts of her images. Finally, she constructs contact sheets to curate her own version of the history of modern architecture; for example, combining the 7th-century Ellora Caves with Bijoy Jain's contemporary Studio Mumbai. The exhibition expands into CSMVS, with interventions in the Textile and Natural History galleries.

For Singh, the labour of photography lies not in the making of images but in conceptualising the forms within which they are disseminated. A suite of museums (modular wooden frames) is presented empty, with the bare structure offering a new architecture for the space the exhibition inhabits. Four-sided pillars display images of architecture by three masters—Geoffrey Bawa, Le Corbusier and B.V. Doshi. By presenting images in these ways, Singh invites the viewer to engage with the work not just with their eyes but with their body, like one would with a sculpture by walking around it and viewing it from different angles. "I want you to get down on your knees if you want to see the lowest picture in the Bawa Rocks pillar; I think you will experience the images very differently then. Similarly, when you look at the montages through the empty museum structures, you will see them differently," says Singh.

The deception in photography is evident throughout the exhibition, particularly in the "montages"

In addition to *Photo Lies*, simultaneous exhibitions have opened at the Jaipur Centre for Art, Jaipur, and at the inaugural Bengal Biennale at Indian Museum, Kolkata. Here, Singh presents Museums of Tanpura, a wide-ranging archive of photos of Indian classical music stalwarts like Pandit Bhimsen Joshi, Pandit Hari Prasad Chaurasia, Ustad Zakir Hussain, Ustad Rashid Khan, Kishori Amonkar and others. While sifting through her photos—many of which were shot while touring the country on the musicians' bus—Singh found the tanpura as a common link be-